

SELMER ELLIPTIC CURVES: SOLUTIONS

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This worksheet studies a single family of plane cubics and uses it to reconstruct, by hand, some of the main results of [Sil09, §§III.1–III.4]: Weierstrass equations, the group law, the Riemann–Roch construction of a Weierstrass model, and a first endomorphism. Sections 1–2 are meant for the problem session; Section 3 may be started there and finished at home; Section 4 is a set of worked Magma examples to read and re-run afterwards, with three short variations to try at the end.

As a rough guide, allow about 12 minutes for §1 and 33 for §2. Within §2, Problem 2.2 is the core and Problem 2.5(e)–(g) the payoff; if time is short, leave Problem 2.5(a)–(d) and Problem 2.6 for later. Section 4 needs no time in the session; it is worked examples, not exercises.

Standing notation. Throughout, k is a field with $\text{char } k \neq 3$, $\bar{k}$ is an algebraic closure of k , and $d \in k^\times$. We write

$$F := X^3 + Y^3 - dZ^3, \quad C_d := \{F = 0\} \subset \mathbb{P}_k^2, \quad O := (1 : -1 : 0),$$

and $\zeta \in \bar{k}$ for a primitive cube root of unity. A pair (C_d, O) of this shape is called a **Selmer elliptic curve**, after [Sel51]; Section 5 explains the name. As usual, X, Y, Z are projective coordinates and lowercase letters are affine coordinates. We write $\bar{C}_d := C_d \times_k \bar{k}$.

1. WARM-UP: A PLANE CUBIC AND A RATIONAL POINT ON IT

Problem 1.1 (It is an elliptic curve).

Recall from [Sil09, §III.3] that an elliptic curve over k is a pair (E, O) with E a smooth, projective, geometrically irreducible curve of genus one over k and $O \in E(k)$ a fixed rational point.

- Check that $O \in C_d(k)$.
- Compute the three partial derivatives of F and deduce that C_d is smooth, using $\text{char } k \neq 3$ and $d \neq 0$. Where is each hypothesis used?
- Suppose instead that $\text{char } k = 3$ (only for this problem). Show that over $\bar{k}$ the curve C_d is a *triple line*.^a
- Show that a smooth plane curve is geometrically irreducible.^b
- Conclude from the degree–genus formula that (C_d, O) is an elliptic curve over k .

^aFrobenius.

^bBézout.

Solution.

(a) $1^3 + (-1)^3 - d \cdot 0 = 0$.

(b) $\partial F / \partial X = 3X^2$, $\partial F / \partial Y = 3Y^2$, $\partial F / \partial Z = -3dZ^2$. If all three vanish at a point of $\mathbb{P}^2(\bar{k})$ then $3X^2 = 3Y^2 = 3dZ^2 = 0$; since $3 \neq 0$ in k we get $X^2 = Y^2 = 0$, and since also $d \neq 0$ we get $Z^2 = 0$. So $X = Y = Z = 0$, which is not a point of $\mathbb{P}^2(\bar{k})$. Both hypotheses are used to divide:

char $k \neq 3$ to cancel the 3, and $d \neq 0$ to cancel d in the third equation. (If $d = 0$ the “curve” $X^3 + Y^3 = 0$ is three concurrent lines.)

(c) In characteristic three the Frobenius $a \mapsto a^3$ is a ring homomorphism, so for $\delta \in \bar{k}$ with $\delta^3 = d$,

$$(X + Y - \delta Z)^3 = X^3 + Y^3 + (-\delta Z)^3 = X^3 + Y^3 - dZ^3 = F.$$

Thus $\overline{C}_d$ is the triple line $\{X + Y - \delta Z = 0\}$: not reduced, hence certainly not smooth, and of arithmetic genus 1 for entirely uninteresting reasons. Note that for $d \notin (k^\times)^3$ the polynomial F is still irreducible *over* k , so the failure is invisible until one passes to $\bar{k}$.

(d) If a plane curve C decomposes as $C_1 \cup C_2$ with C_i of degrees $e_i \geq 1$, then by Bézout $(C_1 \cap C_2)(\bar{k}) \neq \emptyset$, and any point of $(C_1 \cap C_2)(\bar{k})$ is a singular point of C . So a smooth plane curve is irreducible; applied over $\bar{k}$ this gives geometric irreducibility.

(e) A smooth plane curve of degree m has genus $(m-1)(m-2)/2$; for $m = 3$ this is 1. With

(a), (b) and (d), the pair (C_d, O) is an elliptic curve over k .

Problem 1.2 (The base point is an inflection point).

(a) Show that the line $Z = 0$ meets C_d in three *distinct* points of $C_d(\bar{k})$, and write them down. For which k are all three in $C_d(k)$?

(b) Compute the tangent line L to C_d at O , and show that $L \cap C_d = 3O$. (So O is an **inflection point**, or **flex**.)

(c) In a Weierstrass model, which line plays the role of L ? What is different here?

(d) Let $\oplus$ denote the group law on C_d with identity O , defined by the chord–tangent construction of [Sil09, §III.2].^a Using (b), show that for $P, Q, R \in C_d(\bar{k})$,

$$P \oplus Q \oplus R = O \iff P + Q + R \text{ is cut out on } C_d \text{ by a line.}$$

^a[Sil09, Proposition III.3.4] identifies $\oplus$ with addition in $\text{Pic}^0 \overline{C}_d$ via $P \mapsto [P - O]$.

Solution.

(a) Setting $Z = 0$ gives $X^3 = -Y^3$, so $X/Y \in \{-1, -\zeta, -\zeta^2\}$ and the points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ on the line $Z = 0$ are

$$O = (1 : -1 : 0), \quad Q_1 = (1 : -\zeta : 0), \quad Q_2 = (1 : -\zeta^2 : 0).$$

They are distinct because $T^3 + 1$ is separable when char $k \neq 3$. All three lie in $C_d(k)$ exactly when $\zeta \in k$.

(b) From Problem 1.1(b), $\nabla F(O) = (3, 3, 0)$, so $L = \{X + Y = 0\}$. Substituting $X = -Y$ into F gives $(-Y)^3 + Y^3 - dZ^3 = -dZ^3$, which vanishes to order three at $Z = 0$. Hence $L \cap C_d = 3O$.

(c) In a Weierstrass model it is the line at infinity $Z = 0$ that cuts $3O$. Here $Z = 0$ does something different: by (a) it meets C_d in three distinct points of $C_d(\bar{k})$. The flex tangent is instead $X + Y = 0$. It is worth noticing that O being a flex is what makes the group law take the symmetric form in (d); it is not automatic for a plane cubic with a marked rational point.

(d) Write ℓ for a linear form cutting $P + Q + R$ and $\ell_O = X + Y$ for the flex tangent. Then $\text{div}(\ell/\ell_O) = (P + Q + R) - 3O$ in $\text{Div} \overline{C}_d$, so $P + Q + R \sim 3O$. Under the isomorphism $C_d(\bar{k}) \xrightarrow{\sim} \text{Pic}^0 \overline{C}_d$, $P \mapsto [P - O]$, we get

$$P \oplus Q \oplus R \longmapsto [P + Q + R - 3O] = 0,$$

so $P \oplus Q \oplus R = O$. Conversely, suppose $P \oplus Q \oplus R = O$. The line through P and Q meets C_d in a third point $R' \in C_d(\bar{k})$, and the direction just proved gives $P \oplus Q \oplus R' = O$; so $R' = R$, and $P + Q + R$ is cut out by that line.

2. THE GROUP LAW

Problem 2.1 (Negation, and 2-torsion).

- (a) Show that $\ominus(X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) = (Y_0 : X_0 : Z_0)$ for every point $(X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) \in C_d(\bar{k})$. There are two things to check: that the right-hand side lies on C_d , and that it is the third intersection point of C_d with the line through O and $(X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0)$.
- (b) Deduce that the nontrivial 2-torsion of C_d is cut out by the line $X = Y$, and that $\#C_d[2](\bar{k}) = 4$ when $\text{char } k \neq 2$.
- (c) Take $k = \mathbb{Q}$. For which d does C_d have a nontrivial rational 2-torsion point? Write it down, and give the smallest positive integer d for which this happens.

Solution.

(a) F is symmetric in X and Y , so $(Y_0 : X_0 : Z_0) \in C_d(\bar{k})$. For collinearity,

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 \\ X_0 & Y_0 & Z_0 \\ Y_0 & X_0 & Z_0 \end{pmatrix} = 1 \cdot (Y_0 Z_0 - X_0 Z_0) - (-1) \cdot (X_0 Z_0 - Y_0 Z_0) + 0 = 0.$$

Since O is a flex, Problem 1.2(d) gives $O \oplus (X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) \oplus (Y_0 : X_0 : Z_0) = O$, i.e. $(Y_0 : X_0 : Z_0) = \ominus(X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0)$.

(b) For $P = (X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) \in C_d(\bar{k})$, $P = \ominus P$ means $(X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) = (Y_0 : X_0 : Z_0)$ in $\mathbb{P}^2(\bar{k})$. If $Z_0 \neq 0$, normalize $Z_0 = 1$: then $X_0 = Y_0$ and $2X_0^3 = d$, which has three solutions in $\bar{k}$ since $\text{char } k \neq 2$. If $Z_0 = 0$ then P is one of the three $\bar{k}$ -points of Problem 1.2(a), and $(X_0 : Y_0 : 0) = (Y_0 : X_0 : 0)$ means $X_0^2 = Y_0^2$, i.e. $Y_0/X_0 = \pm 1$; of $-1, -\zeta, -\zeta^2$ only -1 qualifies, so $P = O$. Hence the nontrivial 2-torsion consists of the three points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ on the line $X = Y$, and $\#C_d[2](\bar{k}) = 3 + 1 = 4$, as it must be for an elliptic curve in characteristic $\neq 2$.

(c) A nontrivial rational 2-torsion point exists if and only if $d/2 \in (\mathbb{Q}^\times)^3$, say $d = 2c^3$; it is then $(c : c : 1)$. The smallest positive integer is $d = 2$, with the rational point $(1 : 1 : 1)$, i.e. $1^3 + 1^3 = 2$.

Part (b) of Problem 2.2 is its heart; parts (d) and (e) are then mechanical. If time is short, take (b) on faith and come back to its proof, but do not skip (c): it is what makes (e) painless. The identity of (b) is the polarization of a cubic form; for a diagonal cubic the trilinear form can be written down by hand.

Problem 2.2 (The trilinear form, and the addition formulas).

For vectors $P = (X_P, Y_P, Z_P)$, Q and R in $\bar{k}^3$, define

$$(2.1) \quad \langle P, Q, R \rangle := X_P X_Q X_R + Y_P Y_Q Y_R - d Z_P Z_Q Z_R.$$

- (a) Check that (2.1) is symmetric in P, Q, R , linear in each argument separately, and satisfies $\langle P, P, P \rangle = F(P)$.
- (b) Prove the *expansion identity*: for scalars s, t ,

$$(2.2) \quad F(sP + tQ) = s^3 \langle P, P, P \rangle + 3s^2 t \langle P, P, Q \rangle + 3s t^2 \langle P, Q, Q \rangle + t^3 \langle Q, Q, Q \rangle.$$

Where do the 3's come from?^a

(c) Prove that $3\langle P, P, Q \rangle = \nabla F(P) \cdot Q$, and deduce that for $P \in C_d(\bar{k})$,

$$\langle P, P, Q \rangle = 0 \iff Q \text{ lies on the tangent line to } C_d \text{ at } P.$$

(d) Let $P_1 = (X_1 : Y_1 : Z_1)$ and $P_2 = (X_2 : Y_2 : Z_2)$ be distinct points of $C_d(\bar{k})$, and parametrize the line through them as $sP_1 + tP_2$. Using (b), show that the third intersection point is at $(s : t) = (B : -A)$ where $A = \langle P_1, P_1, P_2 \rangle$ and $B = \langle P_1, P_2, P_2 \rangle$, and hence that

$$(2.3) \quad P_1 \oplus P_2 = (BY_1 - AY_2 : BX_1 - AX_2 : BZ_1 - AZ_2).$$

Why can A and B not both vanish?

(e) Let $P = (X_0 : Y_0 : Z_0) \in C_d(\bar{k})$ and put $Q := (Y_0^2 : -X_0^2 : 0)$. Verify that Q lies on the tangent to C_d at P , and use (b) and (c) to derive

$$(2.4) \quad [2]P = (-Y_0(2X_0^3 + Y_0^3) : X_0(X_0^3 + 2Y_0^3) : Z_0(X_0^3 - Y_0^3)).$$

(f) Check (2.4) against Problem 2.1: what does it give on the line $X = Y$? (The line $X = 0$ is taken up in Problem 2.5.)

(g) Where does the whole method break down if $\text{char } k = 3$? Compare your answer with Problem 1.1(c).

^aExpand $\langle sP + tQ, sP + tQ, sP + tQ \rangle$ by trilinearity into eight terms and collect using symmetry.

Solution.

(a) All three properties are visible: each monomial contains exactly one coordinate from each of P, Q, R , so the expression is linear in each argument; permuting P, Q, R permutes the factors within each monomial; and setting $P = Q = R$ gives $X_P^3 + Y_P^3 - dZ_P^3 = F(P)$.

(b) Expanding $\langle sP + tQ, sP + tQ, sP + tQ \rangle$ by linearity in each slot gives $2^3 = 8$ terms, indexed by which of sP, tQ goes into each slot. By the symmetry of (a), the value depends only on *how many* slots receive tQ : there are $\binom{3}{1} = 3$ terms with one tQ , each equal to $s^2t \langle P, P, Q \rangle$, and $\binom{3}{2} = 3$ terms with two. The 3's are binomial coefficients.

(c) Both sides equal $3(X_P^2X_Q + Y_P^2Y_Q - dZ_P^2Z_Q)$: indeed $\nabla F(P) = (3X_P^2, 3Y_P^2, -3dZ_P^2)$. The tangent line to C_d at a smooth point P is $\{\nabla F(P) \cdot (X, Y, Z) = 0\}$, so $\langle P, P, Q \rangle = 0$ says exactly that Q lies on it.

(d) Since $F(P_1) = F(P_2) = 0$, (2.2) reduces to

$$F(sP_1 + tP_2) = 3s^2tA + 3st^2B = 3st(As + Bt).$$

This binary cubic in $(s : t)$ has roots $(1 : 0)$, $(0 : 1)$ and $(B : -A)$; the first two are P_1 and P_2 , so the third intersection point is $BP_1 - AP_2$. Composing with $\ominus$ from Problem 2.1(a), which swaps the first two coordinates, gives (2.3). If $A = B = 0$ then F vanishes identically on the line, so the line would be a component of C_d , contradicting irreducibility (Problem 1.1(d)).

(e) $\langle P, P, Q \rangle = X_0^2Y_0^2 + Y_0^2(-X_0^2) - dZ_0^2 \cdot 0 = 0$, so Q is on the tangent by (c). Now (2.2) loses two terms:

$$F(sP + tQ) = 3st^2 \langle P, Q, Q \rangle + t^3F(Q).$$

The double root at $t = 0$ is the tangency at P ; the third root gives the third intersection point of the tangent with C_d , call it $P * P$:

$$P * P = -F(Q)P + 3\langle P, Q, Q \rangle Q.$$

Here $F(Q) = Y_0^6 - X_0^6$ and $\langle P, Q, Q \rangle = X_0Y_0^4 + Y_0X_0^4 = X_0Y_0(X_0^3 + Y_0^3) = dX_0Y_0Z_0^3$. Substituting and using $dZ_0^3 = X_0^3 + Y_0^3$ to simplify, each coordinate acquires the factor $X_0^3 + Y_0^3$;

cancelling it and applying $\ominus$ gives (2.4). Explicitly, the first coordinate before cancelling is $X_0(X_0^6 - Y_0^6) + 3dX_0Y_0^3Z_0^3 = X_0(X_0^3 + Y_0^3)(X_0^3 + 2Y_0^3)$.

(f) If $X_0 = Y_0$, then $[2]P = (-3X_0^4 : 3X_0^4 : 0) = (1 : -1 : 0) = O$, consistent with Problem 2.1(b).

(g) The middle coefficients of (2.2) are literally 3. In characteristic three the identity collapses to $F(sP + tQ) = s^3F(P) + t^3F(Q)$, which vanishes identically once P and Q represent points of $C_d(\bar{k})$: every line “meets” the cubic everywhere and the chord–tangent construction carries no information at all. This is the same degeneration as in Problem 1.1(c), seen from the side of the group law.

Problem 2.3 (Arithmetic on C_7).

Let $d = 7$, so that $P := (2 : -1 : 1) \in C_7(\mathbb{Q})$ because $2^3 + (-1)^3 = 7$.

- (a) Compute $[2]P$ using (2.4), and simplify. Verify your answer by exhibiting an identity between cubes of integers.
- (b) Compute $[3]P$ using (2.3) applied to P and $[2]P$, and verify it the same way.
- (c) Compute $[4]P$.
- (d) The three rational points you have found have numerators and denominators of rapidly increasing size. What does this suggest about the order of P in $C_7(\mathbb{Q})$? (You are not asked to prove it; see [Sil09, §VIII.9] or [HS00, Part B].)

Solution.

(a) With $X_0 = 2$, $Y_0 = -1$, $Z_0 = 1$ we have $X_0^3 = 8$ and $Y_0^3 = -1$, so

$$[2]P = (-(-1)(16 - 1) : 2(8 - 2) : 1 \cdot (8 + 1)) = (15 : 12 : 9) = (5 : 4 : 3),$$

and indeed $5^3 + 4^3 = 125 + 64 = 189 = 7 \cdot 27 = 7 \cdot 3^3$.

(b) With $P_1 = (2, -1, 1)$ and $P_2 = (5, 4, 3)$,

$$A = 4 \cdot 5 + 1 \cdot 4 - 7 \cdot 1 \cdot 3 = 20 + 4 - 21 = 3, \quad B = 2 \cdot 25 + (-1) \cdot 16 - 7 \cdot 1 \cdot 9 = 50 - 16 - 63 = -29.$$

Then (2.3) gives $[3]P = (-29(-1) - 3 \cdot 4 : -29 \cdot 2 - 3 \cdot 5 : -29 - 9) = (17 : -73 : -38) = (-17 : 73 : 38)$, and $73^3 - 17^3 = 389017 - 4913 = 384104 = 7 \cdot 54872 = 7 \cdot 38^3$.

(c) Doubling $(5 : 4 : 3)$: $X_0^3 = 125$, $Y_0^3 = 64$, so

$$[4]P = (-4(250 + 64) : 5(125 + 128) : 3(125 - 64)) = (-1256 : 1265 : 183),$$

and $1265^3 - 1256^3 = 7 \cdot 183^3$.

(d) If P were a torsion point, its multiples would run through a finite set, so their heights would be bounded; they visibly are not. So P has infinite order, and $C_7(\mathbb{Q})$ has positive rank. In fact the rank is one and P generates modulo torsion.

Fact 2.4 (The Hessian criterion). Let $C = V(F) \subset \mathbb{P}_k^2$ be a smooth plane curve of degree m over a field of characteristic 0 or > 3 , and let

$$H(F) = \det \left(\frac{\partial^2 F}{\partial X_i \partial X_j} \right)_{0 \leq i, j \leq 2}.$$

Then a point $P \in C(\bar{k})$ is an inflection point if and only if $H(F)(P) = 0$. This is classical, and it genuinely fails in characteristic three; see Problem 2.5(h) below.

In Problem 2.5, parts (a)–(c) are the general theory and (e)–(g) the payoff for our family; if time is short, take (c) on faith and go to (e)–(g). Part (d) is the most satisfying: two completely different counts turn out to agree.

Problem 2.5 (Inflection points and 3-torsion).

- (a) Let $C = V(F)$ be as in Fact 2.4. Show that $H(F)$ is a form of degree $3(m - 2)$, so of degree 3 when $m = 3$. Assuming C is a smooth plane cubic, explain why $C \not\subseteq V(H(F))$, and conclude from Bézout [Har77, §I.7] that C has exactly 9 inflection points *counted with multiplicity*.
- (b) Now forget the Hessian. Let C be a smooth plane cubic over $\bar{k}$ and suppose $O \in C(\bar{k})$ is a flex, so that (C, O) is an elliptic curve with the group law of Problem 1.2(d). Show that

$$P \text{ is a flex} \iff [3]P = O,$$

so that the set of flexes is exactly $C[3](\bar{k})$.

- (c) Show that a smooth plane cubic over $\bar{k}$ always *has* a flex, without using the Hessian.^a Deduce that, with no flex singled out, the set of flexes is a torsor under $\text{Pic}^0(C)[3]$; in particular the number of flexes is $\#C[3](\bar{k})$.
- (d) Combine (b) and (c) with the structure of $C[3]$ in characteristic $\neq 3$ to conclude that a smooth plane cubic has exactly 9 flexes. What does comparing this with (a) tell you about the intersection $C \cap V(H(F))$?
- (e) Specialize to C_d . Compute $H(F)$ for $F = X^3 + Y^3 - dZ^3$ and deduce that, as subsets of $C_d(\bar{k})$,

$$C_d[3](\bar{k}) = (C_d \cap \{XYZ = 0\})(\bar{k}).$$

Write down all nine flexes.

- (f) Check (e) against the group law directly: use (2.4) to show that every point $P = (0 : Y_0 : Z_0) \in C_d(\bar{k})$ satisfies $[2]P = \ominus P$.
- (g) Which of the nine flexes lie in $C_d(k)$? Treat the three lines separately, and say what happens for $k = \mathbb{Q}$.
- (h) (★) In characteristic three, $\#C[3](\bar{k})$ is 3 or 1 according as C is ordinary or supersingular, so a smooth plane cubic has 3 or 1 flexes. How is that compatible with (a)?

^aFor any $P_0 \in C(\bar{k})$ the class $\mathcal{O}_C(1) - 3[P_0]$ has degree 0, and multiplication by 3 is surjective on $\text{Pic}^0 C$.

Solution.

(a) Each entry $\partial^2 F / \partial X_i \partial X_j$ is a form of degree $m - 2$, and the determinant of a 3×3 matrix is a sum of products of three entries, so $H(F)$ has degree $3(m - 2)$; for $m = 3$ this is 3. If $C \subseteq V(H(F))$ then by Fact 2.4 every point of $C(\bar{k})$ would be a flex, which is false for a smooth cubic: a curve all of whose $\bar{k}$ -points are flexes is a line (and (b)–(d) below show a smooth cubic has only nine). Hence C and $V(H(F))$ share no component and Bézout applies, giving $\deg(C \cap V(H(F))) = 3 \cdot 3 = 9$.

(b) By definition P is a flex when the tangent line at P meets C at P with multiplicity three, i.e. when the tangent cuts out the divisor $3P$. By Problem 1.2(d) that says $P \oplus P \oplus P = O$, i.e. $[3]P = O$.

(c) Fix any $P_0 \in C(\bar{k})$ and consider the degree-zero class $\mathcal{O}_C(1) - 3[P_0] \in \text{Pic}^0 C$ (here C is already over $\bar{k}$, so no base change is involved). Multiplication by 3 is a nonzero isogeny of the elliptic curve $\text{Pic}^0 C$, hence surjective on $\bar{k}$ -points, so there is a class δ with $3\delta = \mathcal{O}_C(1) - 3[P_0]$. On a genus-one curve with a rational point every degree-zero class has the form $[Q] - [P_0]$, so

$\delta = [Q] - [P_0]$ for some $Q \in C(\bar{k})$, and then $3[Q] \sim \mathcal{O}_C(1)$: the tangent at Q cuts $3Q$, so Q is a flex. Given one flex O , part (b) identifies the flexes with $C[3]$; changing the chosen flex translates this identification, so without a choice the flexes form a torsor under $\text{Pic}^0(C)[3]$ and their number is $\#C[3](\bar{k})$.

(d) For char $k \neq 3$ the multiplication-by-3 map is separable of degree 9, so $C[3](\bar{k}) \simeq (\mathbb{Z}/3)^2$ has exactly 9 elements; by (c) there are exactly 9 flexes. Comparing with (a): nine flexes appear in an intersection of total degree nine, so every intersection multiplicity is 1. That is, C meets its Hessian *transversally*, something the Bézout count alone could not tell us.

(e) The Hessian matrix of $F = X^3 + Y^3 - dZ^3$ is $\text{diag}(6X, 6Y, -6dZ)$, so

$$H(F) = -216 d XYZ.$$

Since $d \neq 0$ and $216 = 2^3 3^3$ is invertible for char $k \neq 2, 3$, we get $V(H(F)) = \{XYZ = 0\}$, and by (b), (d) the nine flexes are $C_d \cap \{XYZ = 0\}$. (In characteristic 2 the Hessian vanishes identically; there, (f) below and the analogue of the tangent computation of Problem 1.2(b) at Q_1, Q_2 give the same nine flexes.) Explicitly, with $\delta \in \bar{k}$ a cube root of d :

$$\begin{aligned} Z = 0 : & \quad (1 : -1 : 0), \quad (1 : -\zeta : 0), \quad (1 : -\zeta^2 : 0), \\ X = 0 : & \quad (0 : \delta : 1), \quad (0 : \zeta\delta : 1), \quad (0 : \zeta^2\delta : 1), \\ Y = 0 : & \quad (\delta : 0 : 1), \quad (\zeta\delta : 0 : 1), \quad (\zeta^2\delta : 0 : 1). \end{aligned}$$

Three on each line, nine in all.

(f) Put $X_0 = 0$ in (2.4); then $Y_0 \neq 0$, since $(0 : 0 : 1) \notin C_d$, and the coordinates become $(-Y_0 \cdot Y_0^3 : 0 : Z_0(0 - Y_0^3)) = (-Y_0^4 : 0 : -Y_0^3 Z_0) = (Y_0 : 0 : Z_0)$, which is $\ominus(0 : Y_0 : Z_0)$ by Problem 2.1(a). So $[2]P = \ominus P$, hence $[3]P = O$, confirming that the points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ on the line $X = 0$ are 3-torsion; and by the symmetry $X \leftrightarrow Y$, likewise those on $Y = 0$.

(g) On $Z = 0$: O is always rational, and Q_1, Q_2 are rational exactly when $\zeta \in k$, by Problem 1.2(a). On $X = 0$ and $Y = 0$: the flex $(0 : \delta : 1)$ is rational if and only if $\delta \in k$, i.e. if and only if $d \in (k^\times)^3$; the remaining four need ζ as well. So over $k = \mathbb{Q}$, where $\zeta \notin \mathbb{Q}$, there are only two possibilities: if d is not a rational cube the only rational flex is O , and if $d = \delta^3$ then $C_d(\mathbb{Q})$ contains exactly three flexes,

$$O, \quad (0 : \delta : 1), \quad (\delta : 0 : 1),$$

which by (f) form a subgroup isomorphic to $\mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$ (the last two are inverse to each other). One can never see all nine over $\mathbb{Q}$.

(h) Both routes to the count are affected, but only one of them is wrong. Fact 2.4 was stated for characteristic 0 or > 3 , and it fails in characteristic three: for instance every second partial derivative of $X^3 + Y^3 + Z^3$ vanishes identically there, so the Hessian carries no information at all. The argument of (b) and (c), by contrast, never mentions the Hessian and is valid in every characteristic; it gives $\#C[3](\bar{k})$ flexes, which is 3 or 1 when char $k = 3$ because $[3]$ is then inseparable. So there is no contradiction: (a) simply does not apply.

Problem 2.6 (Complex multiplication, $\star$).

Let $\alpha(X : Y : Z) = (X : Y : \zeta Z)$, a map defined over $k(\zeta)$.

- (a) Show that α maps C_d to itself and fixes O .
- (b) Quote [Sil09, Theorem III.4.8] to conclude that α is a group homomorphism, hence an automorphism of the elliptic curve (C_d, O) over $k(\zeta)$.
- (c) Show that $\alpha^2 + \alpha + 1 = 0$ in $\text{End}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta))$, the ring of endomorphisms of C_d defined over $k(\zeta)$.^a

- (d) Deduce that $\mathbb{Z}[\zeta] \subseteq \text{End}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta))$, so every Selmer curve has complex multiplication. What does [Sil09, §III.10] then predict for $j(C_d)$ and for $\# \text{Aut}(C_d)$ and $\# \text{Aut}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta))$?

$\alpha^3 = 1$, and the endomorphism ring of an elliptic curve has no zero divisors, [Sil09, §III.4].

Solution.

(a) $F(X, Y, \zeta Z) = X^3 + Y^3 - d\zeta^3 Z^3 = F(X, Y, Z)$ since $\zeta^3 = 1$, so α carries C_d into C_d ; and $\alpha(1 : -1 : 0) = (1 : -1 : 0)$.

(b) α is a morphism of curves sending O to O ; by [Sil09, Theorem III.4.8] any such morphism is a group homomorphism. It is invertible (with inverse given by ζ^2), so it is an automorphism of (C_d, O) .

(c) $\alpha^3 = \text{id}$ because $\zeta^3 = 1$, so $(\alpha - 1)(\alpha^2 + \alpha + 1) = \alpha^3 - 1 = 0$ in $\text{End}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta))$. The endomorphism ring of an elliptic curve is a ring without zero divisors (degrees multiply), and $\alpha \neq 1$ since $\zeta \neq 1$. Hence $\alpha^2 + \alpha + 1 = 0$.

(d) By (c) the subring of $\text{End}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta))$ generated by α is a quotient of $\mathbb{Z}[T]/(T^2 + T + 1) = \mathbb{Z}[\zeta]$. It is torsion-free, because the endomorphism ring is [Sil09, §III.4], and every proper quotient of $\mathbb{Z}[\zeta]$ is finite; so $\mathbb{Z}[\zeta] \subseteq \text{End}(C_d \times_k k(\zeta)) \subseteq \text{End}(\overline{C}_d)$. In particular the endomorphism ring is strictly larger than $\mathbb{Z}$, which is complex multiplication. A curve admitting an automorphism of order three has $j = 0$; and by [Sil09, Theorem III.10.1], in characteristic $\neq 2, 3$ a curve with $j = 0$ has automorphism group of order 6 over a field containing ζ , and order 2 otherwise. For $k = \mathbb{Q}$ we expect $\# \text{Aut}(C_d) = 2$ and $\# \text{Aut}(C_d \times_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{Q}(\zeta)) = 6$; Example 4.2 confirms this in Magma.

3. FROM RIEMANN–ROCH TO A WEIERSTRASS EQUATION

This section reproduces, for our family, the proof of [Sil09, Proposition III.3.1]: every elliptic curve is isomorphic to a curve in Weierstrass form. You may use the following two facts without proof.

Fact 3.1 (Bézout). For a nonzero linear form h , the scheme-theoretic intersection $h \cap C_d$ is an effective divisor of degree 3 in $\text{Div } C_d$; over $\bar{k}$ it becomes a sum of three points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ counted with multiplicity. Consequently, since $X + Y$ cuts out $3O$ by Problem 1.2(b),

$$\text{div}\left(\frac{h}{X + Y}\right) = (h \cap C_d) - 3O.$$

Fact 3.2 (Riemann–Roch for genus one). For every $n \geq 1$ we have $\dim_k \mathcal{L}(nO) = n$, where for $D \in \text{Div } C_d$

$$\mathcal{L}(D) = \{f \in k(C_d)^\times : \text{div}(f) \geq -D\} \cup \{0\}, \quad \text{div}(f) \in \text{Div } C_d.$$

This is a space of functions defined over k ; since C_d is geometrically integral, $\mathcal{L}(D) \otimes_k \bar{k} = \mathcal{L}(D_{\bar{k}})$, so the dimension is the same whether computed over k or over $\bar{k}$. See [Sil09, §II.5] and the proof of [Sil09, Proposition III.3.1].

Problem 3.3 is meant to be finished at home. Parts (a)–(c) go quickly once you see that Fact 3.1 converts “pole order at O ” into “multiplicity of O in $h \cap C_d$ ”. Part (e) is a two-line computation with a surprising answer, and (h) is worth bringing to the next session.

Problem 3.3 (The Weierstrass model of C_d).

Consider the rational functions in $k(C_d)$

$$w := \frac{Z}{X+Y}, \quad v := \frac{X-Y}{X+Y}.$$

For parts (b)–(f) and (h) assume $\text{char } k \neq 2$. Part (g) replaces v by $X/(X+Y) = (1+v)/2$, which also makes sense in characteristic 2, and reaches a model valid whenever $\text{char } k \neq 3$.

- (a) Using Problem 1.2(a) and Fact 3.1, compute $\text{div}(w)$. Deduce that w has a pole of order exactly 2 at O and no other pole, so $w \in \mathcal{L}(2O)$. Where are its zeros, and what are they in the language of Problem 2.5?
- (b) Show that the line $X - Y = 0$ does not pass through O . Deduce that v has a pole of order exactly 3 at O , so $v \in \mathcal{L}(3O)$. Where are its zeros?
- (c) Using Fact 3.2, explain why $\{1, w\}$ is a basis of $\mathcal{L}(2O)$ and $\{1, w, v\}$ is a basis of $\mathcal{L}(3O)$.
- (d) The seven functions $1, w, v, w^2, wv, w^3, v^2$ all lie in $\mathcal{L}(6O)$. Why must they satisfy a non-trivial linear relation over k ? List their pole orders at O ; which two collide, and why does that force the relation to involve both?
- (e) Find the relation.^a
- (f) Let $E_1: y_1^2 = x_1^3 - 432d^2$. Show that the relation of (e) says that there is a morphism $\varphi_1: C_d \rightarrow E_1$ with $\varphi_1^*x_1 = 12dw$ and $\varphi_1^*y_1 = 36dv$. Write down φ_1 and its inverse explicitly.
- (g) Where exactly did you use $\text{char } k \neq 2$? Show that there is instead a morphism φ_2 with $\varphi_2^*x_2 = 3dw$ and $\varphi_2^*y_2 = 9dX/(X+Y)$ to

$$(3.1) \quad E_2: y_2^2 - 9dy_2 = x_2^3 - 27d^2,$$

which is a Weierstrass equation in the sense of [Sil09, §III.1] valid whenever $\text{char } k \neq 3$. Which of $a_1, \dots, a_6$ are nonzero?

- (h) (★) The relation in (e) has no w^2, wv, w or v term, although [Sil09, Proposition III.3.1] allows all four. Explain why, using the automorphisms $\sigma = \ominus$ of Problem 2.1 and α of Problem 2.6.^b

^aWork on the affine chart $X+Y=1$, where $X=(1+v)/2$ and $Y=(1-v)/2$, and expand X^3+Y^3 .

^bCompute $\sigma^*w, \sigma^*v, \alpha^*w, \alpha^*v$; then use (d) to argue that the relation spans a one-dimensional space, so it is a simultaneous eigenvector.

Solution.

(a) By Problem 1.2(a), $Z \cap C_d = O + Q_1 + Q_2$ with $Q_1, Q_2 \neq O$. So $\text{div}(w) = O + Q_1 + Q_2 - 3O = Q_1 + Q_2 - 2O$. Hence the only pole is at O , of order exactly 2. This last computation is an identity in $\text{Div } \bar{C}_d$; in $\text{Div } C_d$, when $\zeta \notin k$, the pair $\{Q_1, Q_2\}$ is a *single* closed point $\mathfrak{q}$ of degree 2 (see Warning 4.1), and the same statement reads $\text{div}(w) = \mathfrak{q} - 2O$. Either way the degree is 0 and the pole order at O is 2. Its zeros Q_1, Q_2 are, by Problem 2.5(e) and Problem 1.2(a), the nontrivial 3-torsion points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ on the line $Z = 0$.

(b) The form $X - Y$ takes the value $1 - (-1) = 2$ at O , which is nonzero since $\text{char } k \neq 2$. (In characteristic 2, $X - Y = X + Y$ vanishes at O ; that is why (g) avoids v .) So O does not appear in $(X - Y) \cap C_d$ and $\text{div}(v) = ((X - Y) \cap C_d) - 3O$ has a pole of order exactly 3 at O . Its zeros are the three points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ on the line $X = Y$, i.e. the nontrivial 2-torsion of Problem 2.1(b); in $\text{Div } C_d$ these assemble into closed points of total degree 3.

(c) $\mathcal{L}(O)$ has dimension 1 by Fact 3.2 and contains the constants, so $\mathcal{L}(O) = k$. Now $\dim \mathcal{L}(2O) = 2$ and $1, w \in \mathcal{L}(2O)$ are independent because $w \notin k$ (it has a pole); so $\{1, w\}$

is a basis. Similarly $\dim \mathcal{L}(3O) = 3$ and $v \in \mathcal{L}(3O) \setminus \mathcal{L}(2O)$ since its pole order is 3, so $\{1, w, v\}$ is a basis.

(d) The seven functions lie in $\mathcal{L}(6O)$, which has dimension 6 by Fact 3.2; seven vectors in a 6-dimensional space are dependent. Their pole orders at O are

$$1, w, v, w^2, wv, w^3, v^2 \longmapsto 0, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 6.$$

The first five have *distinct* pole orders, hence are linearly independent (a nontrivial combination has a pole of order equal to the largest one occurring). So any relation must involve w^3 or v^2 ; and since these are the only two with pole order exactly 6, a relation involving one must involve the other, with the leading terms cancelling. It also follows that the space of relations is exactly one-dimensional.

(e) On the chart $X + Y = 1$ we have $w = Z$ and $v = X - Y$, so $X = (1 + v)/2$, $Y = (1 - v)/2$, and

$$X^3 + Y^3 = \frac{(1 + v)^3 + (1 - v)^3}{8} = \frac{2 + 6v^2}{8} = \frac{3v^2 + 1}{4}.$$

The defining equation $X^3 + Y^3 = dZ^3$ therefore reads

$$(3.2) \quad 3v^2 + 1 = 4dw^3.$$

(f) Multiplying (3.2) by $432d^2$ gives

$$(36dv)^2 + 432d^2 = (12dw)^3,$$

so the functions $12dw$ and $36dv$ satisfy the equation of E_1 , and this defines φ_1 . Explicitly,

$$\varphi_1(X : Y : Z) = \left(\frac{12dZ}{X + Y}, \frac{36d(X - Y)}{X + Y} \right), \quad \varphi_1^{-1}(x_1, y_1) = (36d + y_1 : 36d - y_1 : 6x_1).$$

That φ_1^{-1} lands on C_d is a one-line check: $(36d + y_1)^3 + (36d - y_1)^3 = 2(36d)^3 + 216dy_1^2$ while $d(6x_1)^3 = 216d(y_1^2 + 432d^2)$, and $2 \cdot 36^3 = 216 \cdot 432 = 93312$.

(g) The hypothesis $\text{char } k \neq 2$ was used twice: to divide by 2 when solving for X and Y in terms of v , and, more seriously, to complete the square, which is what reaches the form $y^2 = x^3 + a_6$. For φ_2 , work on the chart $X + Y = 1$, where $\varphi_2^*y_2 = 9dX$ and $X - 1 = -Y$, so $(\varphi_2^*y_2)^2 - 9d\varphi_2^*y_2 = 81d^2X(X - 1) = -81d^2XY$. Meanwhile $X^3 + Y^3 = (X + Y)^3 - 3XY(X + Y) = 1 - 3XY$, and this equals dw^3 , so $XY = (1 - dw^3)/3$ and

$$(\varphi_2^*y_2)^2 - 9d\varphi_2^*y_2 = -27d^2(1 - dw^3) = 27d^3w^3 - 27d^2 = (\varphi_2^*x_2)^3 - 27d^2.$$

No division by 2 occurred, and the identity holds whenever $\text{char } k \neq 3$. In the notation of [Sil09, §III.1] this is $a_1 = a_2 = a_4 = 0$, $a_3 = -9d$, $a_6 = -27d^2$. This is exactly why the general Weierstrass equation carries the coefficients a_1 and a_3 that one is tempted to discard.

(h) From the definitions, $\sigma(X : Y : Z) = (Y : X : Z)$ and $\alpha(X : Y : Z) = (X : Y : \zeta Z)$ give

$$\sigma^*w = w, \quad \sigma^*v = -v, \quad \alpha^*w = \zeta w, \quad \alpha^*v = v.$$

By (d) the space of relations among the seven monomials is one-dimensional. Both σ^* and α^* multiply each monomial by a scalar, so they preserve that space and act on it by a scalar: the relation is a simultaneous eigenvector. It involves w^3 and v^2 , and $\sigma^*w^3 = w^3$, $\sigma^*v^2 = v^2$, $\alpha^*w^3 = w^3$, $\alpha^*v^2 = v^2$; both are fixed. So both eigenvalues are 1, and every monomial that is *not* fixed by both must have coefficient zero. Those are v and wv (negated by σ^*) and w, w^2, wv (scaled by α^*): precisely the four missing terms. The shape of the Weierstrass equation is dictated by the automorphism group.

4. WORKED EXAMPLES IN MAGMA

Most of you have never opened Magma, so this section is written as worked examples rather than exercises: read them, then re-run them yourself and change things. Every line of output below is reproduced from Magma V2.28-8 [BCP97], with whitespace tidied and one long type name elided. Three short variations to try on your own are collected at the end.

Warning 4.1 (Closed points in Magma). A **closed point** P of C_d is a point of the scheme C_d ; its residue field $k(P)$ is a finite extension of k , and $\deg P := [k(P) : k]$. The closed points of degree one are the rational points, and a closed point P with $k(P)/k$ separable corresponds to an orbit of $\deg P$ points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ under $\text{Gal}(k^{\text{sep}}/k)$. The divisor group $\text{Div } C_d$ is the free abelian group on the closed points [Poo06, §1.9], whereas [Sil09, §II.3] works with points of $C_d(\bar{k})$ and Galois-invariant divisors on $\bar{C}_d$. Magma follows the first convention: **Places** returns closed points, **Divisor** builds elements of $\text{Div } C_d$, and **RiemannRochSpace** returns $\mathcal{L}(D)$ as a k -vector space.

Each example continues the previous one; begin with

```

QQ := Rational();
P2<X,Y,Z> := ProjectiveSpace(QQ,2);
d := 7;
C := Curve(P2, X^3 + Y^3 - d*Z^3);
O := C![1,-1,0];

```

The notation $P2<X,Y,Z>$ names the coordinates so that we can write equations in them, and **C!** coerces a list of three numbers into a rational point of **C**; typing $O := (1:-1:0)$; does not work.

Example 4.2 (Setting up, and a trap). First, Problem 1.1:

```

IsNonSingular(C); // true
Genus(C);         // 1
O;                // (-1 : 1 : 0)

```

The last line is worth a pause. We asked for $(1 : -1 : 0)$ and got $(-1 : 1 : 0)$: a point of $\mathbb{P}^2(\mathbb{Q})$ is defined only up to scaling, and Magma normalizes the representative it stores, here by -1 .

Now ask for the Weierstrass model. The second return value **mp** is the isomorphism from **C** to **E**.

```

E, mp := EllipticCurve(C, O);
E;
// Elliptic Curve defined by y^2 - 9/49*y = x^3 - 27/2401 over Rational Field
jInvariant(E); // 0
E eq EllipticCurve([0,0,0,0,-432*d^2]); // false

```

That **false** looks alarming, since Problem 3.3(f) says the answer should be $E_1: y_1^2 = x_1^3 - 432d^2$. It is not a contradiction: **eq** compares Weierstrass *coefficients*, and by [Sil09, Proposition III.3.1(b)] a Weierstrass model is unique only up to the changes of variables $x = u^2x' + r$, $y = u^3y' + su^2x' + t$. The right question is whether the curves are isomorphic, and against which model:

```

Eours := EllipticCurve([0,0,-9*d,0,-27*d^2]);
Eours; // y^2 - 63*y = x^3 - 1323
bool, iso := IsIsomorphic(Eours, E);
bool; // true
IsomorphismData(iso); // [ 0, 0, 0, 1/7 ]

```

So $r = s = t = 0$ and $u = 1/7 = 1/d$: **Magma** found exactly the model E_2 of Problem 3.3(g), with x_2 and y_2 divided by d^2 and d^3 . The two maps agree as well,

```
DefiningEquations(mp);    // [ 3/7*Z, 9/49*X, X + Y ]
```

against our $(3dZ : 9dX : X + Y)$, the ratios being d^2 and d^3 exactly as $u = 1/d$ demands. The moral: for elliptic curves, **eq** is almost never the question you mean to ask.

We can even watch this happen for all d at once, by working over the function field $\mathbb{Q}(d)$ instead of over $\mathbb{Q}$:

```
Fd<D> := FunctionField(Rationals());
P2d<Xd,Yd,Zd> := ProjectiveSpace(Fd,2);
Cd := Curve(P2d, Xd^3 + Yd^3 - D*Zd^3);
Ed, mpd := EllipticCurve(Cd, Cd![1,-1,0]);
Ed;
// Elliptic Curve defined by y^2 - 9/D^2*y = x^3 - 27/D^4
DefiningEquations(mpd);
// [ 3/D*Zd, 9/D^2*Xd, Xd + Yd ]
```

which is (3.1) rescaled by $u = d$, as an identity in d .

Finally, the predictions of Problem 2.6(d):

```
#AutomorphismGroup(E);          // 2
K<zeta> := CyclotomicField(3);
#AutomorphismGroup(BaseChange(E,K));    // 6
```

Example 4.3 (The addition formulas, checked). A **Magma** function takes arguments and returns a value; here both are sequences of three coordinates, so that (2.3) and (2.4) can be typed almost verbatim.

```
dbl := function(P)
  x := P[1]; y := P[2]; z := P[3];
  return [-y*(2*x^3+y^3), x*(x^3+2*y^3), z*(x^3-y^3)];
end function;

add := function(P1,P2)
  A := P1[1]^2*P2[1] + P1[2]^2*P2[2] - d*P1[3]^2*P2[3];
  B := P1[1]*P2[1]^2 + P1[2]*P2[2]^2 - d*P1[3]*P2[3]^2;
  return [B*P1[2]-A*P2[2], B*P1[1]-A*P2[1], B*P1[3]-A*P2[3]];
end function;

P := [2,-1,1];
Q := dbl(P);    C!Q;    // (5/3 : 4/3 : 1)
R := dbl(Q);    C!R;    // (-1256/183 : 1265/183 : 1)
S := add(P,Q);  C!S;    // (-17/38 : 73/38 : 1)
```

These are the rational points of Problem 2.3. Coercing through **c!** normalizes them, which is why $(15 : 12 : 9)$ prints as $(5/3 : 4/3 : 1)$. Now transport everything to E through **mp** and compare with **Magma**'s own group law:

```
EP := mp(C!P);
```

```

mp(C!Q) eq 2*EP;      // true
mp(C!S) eq 3*EP;      // true
mp(C!R) eq 4*EP;      // true

```

Three `true`s: formulas derived from nothing but (2.1) and a 3×3 determinant agree with a general-purpose implementation.

Example 4.4 (Riemann–Roch, mechanically). `Magma` can carry out Problem 3.3 without being told the answer. The generators `x` and `y` of `FunctionField(C)` are the affine coordinates X/Z and Y/Z of C_d (not Weierstrass coordinates), so our two functions are built from those.

```

FF<x,y> := FunctionField(C);    // x = X/Z,  y = Y/Z
w := 1/(x+y);                  // Z/(X+Y)
v := (x-y)/(x+y);              // (X-Y)/(X+Y)
p10 := Place(0);
Valuation(w, p10);              // -2
Valuation(v, p10);              // -3

```

Those are the pole orders of Problem 3.3(a), (b); a valuation of -2 is a pole of order 2. As in Warning 4.1, `Place(0)` is the closed point O and `Divisor` builds an element of $\text{Div } C_d$, so everything here happens over $\mathbb{Q}$. Next, Fact 3.2 itself:

```

D := Divisor(p10);
for n in [1..6] do print n, Dimension(RiemannRochSpace(n*D)); end for;
// 1 1
// 2 2
// 3 3
// 4 4
// 5 5
// 6 6

```

Now ask for a basis of $\mathcal{L}(2O)$ without suggesting one:

```

V2, m2 := RiemannRochSpace(2*D);
[m2(b) : b in Basis(V2)];      // [ x^2 - y*x + y^2, 1 ]

```

which looks nothing like our w . But $X^3 + Y^3 = (X + Y)(X^2 - XY + Y^2)$, and on C_d the left side is dZ^3 , so

$$\frac{X^2 - XY + Y^2}{Z^2} = \frac{dZ^3}{Z^2(X + Y)} = d \frac{Z}{X + Y} = dw,$$

and indeed

```

(x^2 - x*y + y^2) eq d*w;      // true

```

Finally the relation. We list the seven functions of Problem 3.3(d), express each in a basis of $\mathcal{L}(6O)$ (that is what `@@` does, applying the inverse of the map `mV`), and take the kernel of the resulting matrix.

```

V, mV := RiemannRochSpace(6*D);
fns := [FF!1, w, v, w^2, w*v, w^3, v^2];

```

```

[-Valuation(f, p10) : f in fns]; // [ 0, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 6 ]
M := Matrix([Eltseq(f @@ mV) : f in fns]);
K := Kernel(M);
Dimension(K); // 1
Basis(K); // [ ( 1 0 0 0 0 -28 3) ]

```

The pole orders are 0, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6: seven functions, six available orders, the collision at 6 forcing the relation exactly as in Problem 3.3(d). And the kernel is one-dimensional, spanned by the vector reading

$$1 - 28w^3 + 3v^2 = 0,$$

which is $3v^2 + 1 = 4dw^3$ at $d = 7$. We got it by hand from a factorization; Magma got it from linear algebra in a Riemann–Roch space.

Now try these. Each one is a small edit to Example 4.2 or Example 4.3, and in each case the worksheet already tells you what the answer must be.

- (1) Set $d := 2$. Problem 2.1(c) predicts a rational point of order two. Find it, verify with the group law that it has order two, and compute its image under φ_1 by hand.
- (2) Set $d := 8$. Problem 2.5(g) predicts rational 3-torsion. Find the two rational 3-torsion points other than O , use your `dbl` function to check that $[2]P = \ominus P$, and compute $\varphi_1(P)$ by hand.
- (3) Use `IsIsomorphic` to decide whether $C_1 \simeq C_8$ and whether $C_1 \simeq C_2$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. Pass it the *Weierstrass* models: on the plane curves themselves Magma answers `For genus 0 or 1 curves the basefield must be finite`. Reconcile the answers with the cubic-twist criterion of Section 5.

Solution.

(1) $d = 2 = 2 \cdot 1^3$, so by Problem 2.1(c) the rational 2-torsion point is $(1 : 1 : 1)$, and indeed $1^3 + 1^3 = 2$. Then

$$\varphi_1(1 : 1 : 1) = \left(\frac{12 \cdot 2 \cdot 1}{1 + 1}, \frac{36 \cdot 2 \cdot 0}{1 + 1} \right) = (12, 0),$$

which lies on $E_1 : y_1^2 = x_1^3 - 432 \cdot 4 = x_1^3 - 1728$ because $12^3 = 1728$. A point of $E_1(\bar{k})$ with $y_1 = 0$ is exactly a point of order two. Equivalently `dbl([1,1,1])` returns $(-3 : 3 : 0) = O$.

(2) $d = 8 = 2^3$, so $\delta = 2$ and the rational flexes are $(2 : 0 : 1)$ and $(0 : 2 : 1)$ besides O . Doubling: `dbl([2,0,1])` gives $(-0 : 2(8 + 0) : 1(8 - 0)) = (0 : 16 : 8) = (0 : 2 : 1)$, which is $\ominus(2 : 0 : 1)$, so $[3](2 : 0 : 1) = O$. By hand,

$$\varphi_1(2 : 0 : 1) = \left(\frac{12 \cdot 8 \cdot 1}{2}, \frac{36 \cdot 8 \cdot 2}{2} \right) = (48, 288),$$

and $48^3 - 432 \cdot 64 = 110592 - 27648 = 82944 = 288^2$.

(3) Over $\mathbb{Q}$ the curves $y_1^2 = x_1^3 + A_1$ and $y_2^2 = x_2^3 + A_2$ are isomorphic exactly when A_1/A_2 is a sixth power. For C_1 and C_8 we get $-432/(-432 \cdot 64) = 1/64 = (1/2)^6$, so `IsIsomorphic(EllipticCurve(C1,01), EllipticCurve(C8,08))` returns `true`; consistently, $1/8 = (1/2)^3$ is a cube. For C_1 and C_2 we get $1/4$, which is not a sixth power in $\mathbb{Q}^\times$ (that would need $2^{-1/3} \in \mathbb{Q}$), so the answer is `false`; consistently, 2 is not a rational cube. This is the criterion of Section 5: $C_d \simeq C_{d'}$ over k if and only if $d/d' \in (k^\times)^3$.

5. WHERE THE NAME COMES FROM

Selmer [Sel51] studied the general diagonal cubic $aX^3 + bY^3 + cZ^3 = 0$, and produced the standard counterexample to the Hasse principle: the curve $3X^3 + 4Y^3 + 5Z^3 = 0$ has real points and $\mathbb{Q}_p$ -points

for every prime p , but no rational point. Such a curve is a torsor under its Jacobian [Poo17, §5.12], and that Jacobian is a Selmer curve in our sense:

$$\text{Jac}(aX^3 + bY^3 + cZ^3) \simeq (y^2 = x^3 - 432(abc)^2).$$

Two ways to test this in **Magma**: the curve $X^3 + 2Y^3 + 3Z^3 = 0$ *does* have the rational point $(1 : 1 : -1)$, so it is its own Jacobian and should be isomorphic to C_6 , that is to $y^2 = x^3 - 432 \cdot 6^2$; and for Selmer’s own curve one can call `Jacobian(GenusOneModel(3*X^3 + 4*Y^3 + 5*Z^3))` and compare with $y^2 = x^3 - 432 \cdot 60^2$. Both come out `true`.

Finally, by Problem 3.3(f) together with the classification of twists of $y^2 = x^3 + A$ [Sil09, §X.5], for char $k \neq 2, 3$ the curves C_d and $C_{d'}$ are isomorphic over k exactly when $d/d' \in (k^\times)^3$, so the family is parametrized by $k^\times/(k^\times)^3$. These are the **cubic twists** of $X^3 + Y^3 = Z^3$, and they are the natural first examples for the descent machinery of [Sil09, §X] and [Poo17, Ch. 8].

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